

**BELARUS****Capital city:** Minsk**Area:** 80,154 sq miles
(207,600 sq km)**Population:** 9,900,000**Official language:**
Belorussian, Russian**Major religions:** Christian
68%, other 32%**Government:** Multiparty
democracy**Currency:** Belarian
rouble**Adult literacy rate:** 99%**Life expectancy:** 68 years**People per doctor:** 222**Televisions:** 314 per 1,000
people

BELARUS

THIS POOR, RURAL republic is sparsely populated and has few natural resources. However, living conditions have improved greatly since the 1960s when a drive began to develop industry and to provide better housing. In 1986, an explosion at the Chernobyl nuclear power station in Ukraine seriously affected people's health across the country. Two hundred years of Russian rule ended in 1991 with the breakup of the former USSR, and Belarus became an independent republic.

**PRIPET MARSHES**

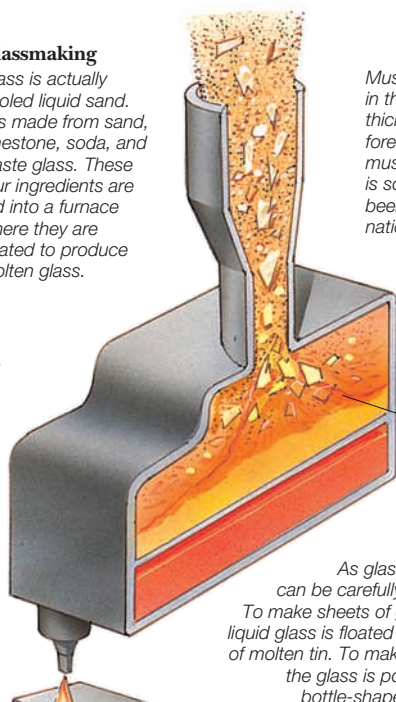
Huge areas of southern Belarus are covered in misty, marshy land. The Pripet Marshes form the largest expanse of marshland in Europe. Much of this area is forested with pine, alder, aspen, and oak trees, which supply a growing lumber industry. Animals such as elk, lynx, wild boar, and grouse have made the marshes and forests their home.

LOCAL FOODS

Mushrooms and potatoes are staple foods. Potatoes cooked in different ways are eaten for breakfast, lunch, and dinner. Mushrooms and sour cream are served with meat dishes, such as baked rabbit or pork. In addition to being enjoyed fresh, mushrooms may be dried or salted and pickled.

Glassmaking

Glass is actually cooled liquid sand. It is made from sand, limestone, soda, and waste glass. These four ingredients are fed into a furnace where they are heated to produce molten glass.



Dried chanterelle mushrooms

Mushrooms flourish in the country's thick, damp forests, and mushroom picking is so popular it has been called the national sport.

Boletus or cèpe mushrooms

The furnace is heated up to 2,550°F (1,400°C) to melt the raw ingredients.

As glass cools, it can be carefully shaped. To make sheets of glass, the liquid glass is floated on a river of molten tin. To make bottles, the glass is poured into bottle-shaped molds.

A lump of molten glass called a gob is dropped into a mold.

The liquid glass sinks to the far end.

Air is blown in to make the glass fill the mold.

The glass bottle is left to cool and set before being taken out of the mold.

**EDUCATION**

During the rule of the USSR, almost everyone in Belarus was taught to read and write. Education was free between the ages of 7 and 17. This firm educational foundation has led to the development of a strong literary and musical heritage within the republic.

**MINSK**

The centrally placed capital city has a history of changing fortunes. Although it was devastated by bombing in World War II, in peaceful times Minsk has blossomed as a center of government, education, culture, and communications. Recently, industrial growth has brought rapid expansion to the city. It is also the headquarters of the Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS), an organization that brings former Soviet states together.

Find out more

EDUCATION: 277
EUROPEAN CITIES: 80
FORMER USSR: 134
OIL: 135, 152, 281